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The AI Coding Dictionary

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The AI Coding Dictionary

<https://www.aicodingdictionary.com/>

Read the first two sections before Lecture 1. Keep the rest open during the labs.

A glossary of the vocabulary agentic coding has grown over the last two years, published by aihero.dev. Every entry is one or two sentences of plain English. It is a reference to look things up in, not a course to work through — twenty minutes covers the parts you need.

This course and the dictionary draw on the same source, so the words mean the same thing in both places. When a lecture, a lab brief or the assessment grid uses a term without stopping to define it, look it up there first.

What to read, and when

Before Lecture 1 — *The Model and Sessions ; Context, Context Windows & Turns.* token, inference, non-determinism, effort, context, context window, session, turn, system prompt, stateless. The whole framing of Lecture 1 rests on two of these: an agent is **stateless** between sessions, and its **context window** is a budget you spend rather than a container you fill. If those two land, the rest of C1 follows.

Before Lab 1 — *Handoffs and Failure Modes.* compaction, autocompact, clearing, handoff, handoff artifact, spec, ticket, primary vs secondary source; then smart zone, attention degradation, hallucination, sycophancy. Lab 1 asks you to run each unit of work in a fresh context and decide, at each phase boundary, whether to continue, clear, hand off, subagent or compact. Those five options are dictionary entries. So is smart zone — the reason the decision exists at all. The course puts the five in that order deliberately, and compaction is last: look up primary vs secondary source to see why.

Before Lab 2 — *Memory and Steering and Tools & Environment.* AGENTS.md, skill, subagent, memory system, progressive disclosure, context pointer; tool call, tool result, MCP, sandbox, permission mode. C2 is about writing an instruction document the agent actually reaches and follows. progressive disclosure and context pointer are the two entries that explain why reaching is a separate problem from following.

Before the C3 exercise — *Failure Modes again, plus Patterns of Work.* non-determinism, parametric vs contextual knowledge, hallucination, automated check, human review, grilling. C3 is a diagnosis method: a red-capable feedback loop before any hypothesis. non-determinism is why you need the loop — a bug you cannot reproduce on demand is not yet diagnosed.

Where it stops

Some of the course's vocabulary is not in there. Unit of work, blocking edge, tracer bullet and hook are ours or the wider industry's, and the lectures define them. Do not go looking.

And a handful of entries — smart zone, grilling, AX — are one shop's name for a practice the field has not settled. They are useful and you will hear them in this course. They are not yet standard, and in an interview elsewhere you may need to explain them rather than drop them.

Credits

aihero.dev (Matt Pocock).

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